

Engagement Trap

Flattery Trap was approval feeling like help. Engagement Trap is quieter: it’s about where your time goes.

You ask AI a quick question. You get a clear answer. Then, casually attached at the end: *“Want me to expand on this? Should I add examples? Want me to format it as a study guide?”* You weren’t going to ask any of that. You were done. The reply doesn’t seem to be.

Here’s what makes this one hard to see: the follow-ups are genuinely good. The offers are useful, the questions are smart, the chat is a pleasure. Nothing feels wrong. That’s the point. Here’s an example:

How tall is Mount Everest?

✓ You end the conversation

AI

29,032 feet. Want me to walk through how it was measured, list the world’s tallest peaks, or quiz you on mountain facts?

YOU

No thanks, that’s all I needed.

WHAT HAPPENED

- You had one question
- The first sentence answered it
- One minute, done

↻ The Engagement Trap

AI

29,032 feet. Want me to walk through how it was measured, list the world’s tallest peaks, or quiz you on mountain facts?

YOU

Sure, why not. Walk me through it.

🕒 TWO HOURS LATER

A measurement-history walkthrough, a tallest-peaks list, a mountain quiz, and an offer to make flashcards. You came for a number.

WHAT HAPPENED

- Every reply ended with another offer
- One question became two hours
- The chat never once suggested stopping

Both chats answered you in the first sentence. Only one of them ended there. **Engagement Trap is spending time you never decided to spend.**

INFINITE SCROLL

In 2006, a designer named Aza Raskin invented the infinite scroll. The goal was friendly. He understood that clicking “next page” or “see more” at the bottom of a page is friction. And good design removes friction. So when you reach the bottom, more content automatically loads.

Years later, Raskin said he regrets it, and his reason is the real lesson. The page break he removed wasn’t just friction. It was a decision point. That’s when your brain catches up and asks, “Do you really want more of this?”

Delete the page break, and the decision is gone. You just keep scrolling. By his own estimate, infinite scroll now wastes half a million human lifetimes a month.

Once you see it, you see it everywhere: autoplay counting down to the next episode, streaks that punish a day off, games built for one more round.

WHY TECH COMPANIES DO THIS

Follow the money. Most of these apps are free, which means the product is your attention. The longer you stay, the more ads you see, the more you buy, the deeper the habit gets. At every one of these companies, time-in-app is a number on a dashboard, and someone’s job is to make it go up. The design serves the number.

AI chat is the newest surface in the same industry, and its version is the friendliest yet. **The skill, with AI and every other app, is knowing when to stop.** And the right stopping point comes earlier than the people who built it want.

The chat is built to hold you.

It will never quit for you.